

RUSH

Fifty Something Tour — Songs, Notes & Lyrics

ROTATING SETLIST · 2026

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Xanadu

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

A meditation on immortality, desire, and the trap of getting exactly what one longs for. The narrator pursues the legendary paradise of Xanadu, only to discover that endless life without meaningful change becomes a curse. The song draws on Samuel Taylor Coleridge's 1797 poem "Kubla Khan," while Neil Peart's lyrics turn its romantic fantasy into a darker reflection on mortality. Released on *A Farewell to Kings* (1977), "Xanadu" helped establish Rush's increasingly elaborate progressive-rock approach. The recording features an extensive instrumental introduction and unusual instrumentation, including temple blocks and tubular bells, and became a major concert staple.

LYRICS

[INSTRUMENTAL INTRO]

[VERSE 1]

"To seek the sacred river Alph
To walk the caves of ice
To break my fast on honeydew
And drink the milk of Paradise"

[CHORUS]

I had heard the whispered tales of immortality
The deepest mystery
From an ancient book I took a clue
I scaled the frozen mountain tops of eastern lands unknown
Time and Man alone
Searching for the lost Xanadu

[POST-CHORUS]

Xanadu

[VERSE 2]

To stand within the Pleasure Dome
Decreed by Kubla Khan
To taste anew the fruits of life
The last immortal man
To find the sacred river Alph
To walk the caves of ice
Oh, I will dine on honeydew
And drink the milk of Paradise
Oh, paradise!

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK]

[CHORUS]

A thousand years have come and gone but time has passed me by
Stars stopped in the sky
Frozen in an everlasting view
Waiting for the world to end, weary of the night
Praying for the light
Prison of the lost Xanadu

[POST-CHORUS]

Xanadu

[VERSE 3]

Held within the Pleasure Dome
Decreed by Kubla Khan
To taste my bitter triumph
As a mad immortal man
Nevermore shall I return
Escape these caves of ice
For I have dined on honeydew
And drunk the milk of Paradise
Woah, is it paradise?

[INSTRUMENTAL OUTRO]

The Spirit of Radio

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Permanent Waves (1980), it became one of Rush's best-known songs. Its title references Toronto radio station CFNY-FM's slogan, and the track famously shifts through reggae, progressive rock, and hard-rock passages. A celebration of radio, musical discovery, and the freedom of listening—tempered by Peart's frustration with commercialization and formulaic pop. The song moves from affectionate nostalgia for radio into satire about advertising, repetition, and the erosion of musical independence.

LYRICS

[INSTRUMENTAL INTRO]

[VERSE 1]

Begin the day with a friendly voice
A companion unobtrusive
Plays that song that's so elusive
And the magic music that makes your morning mood

[VERSE 2]

Off on your way, hit the open road
There is magic at your fingers
For the spirit ever lingers
Undemanding contact in your happy solitude

[CHORUS]

Invisible airwaves crackle with life
Bright antennae bristle with the energy
Emotional feedback on a timeless wavelength
Bearing a gift beyond price, almost free

[VERSE 3]

All this machinery making modern music
Can still be open-hearted
Not so coldly charted
It's really just a question of your honesty
Yeah, your honesty
One likes to believe in the freedom of music
But glittering prizes and endless compromises
Shatter the illusion of integrity, yeah

[CHORUS]

Invisible airwaves crackle with life
Bright antennae bristle with the energy
Emotional feedback on a timeless wavelength
Bearing a gift beyond price, almost free

[INSTRUMENTAL INTERLUDE]

[OUTRO]

For the words of the profits were written on the studio wall
The concert hall
And echoes with the sound of salesmen
Of salesmen
Of salesmen

[GUITAR SOLO]

Subdivisions

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

From Signals (1982), "Subdivisions" marked Rush's growing use of synthesizers. Its opening synth texture and sharply observed suburban imagery made it one of the band's most enduring songs about adolescence and social pressure. The song examines conformity, suburban isolation, and the pressure

placed on young people to fit into socially approved paths. Its central idea is that apparently orderly communities can leave individuals feeling anonymous and disconnected.

LYRICS

[INSTRUMENTAL INTRO]

[VERSE 1]

Sprawling on the fringes of the city
In geometric order, an insulated border
In between the bright lights and the far unlit unknown

[VERSE 2]

Growing up, it all seems so one-sided
Opinions all provided, the future pre-decided
Detached and subdivided in the mass production zone
Nowhere is the dreamer or the misfit so alone

[CHORUS: GEDDY LEE & NEIL PEART]

(Subdivisions)—
In the high school halls, in the shopping malls
Conform or be cast out
(Subdivisions)—
In the basement bars, in the backs of cars
Be cool or be cast out

[POST-CHORUS]

Any escape might help to smooth the unattractive truth
But the suburbs have no charms to soothe the restless dreams of youth

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK]

[VERSE 3]

Drawn like moths, we drift into the city
The timeless old attraction, cruising for the action
Lit up like a firefly just to feel the living night

[VERSE 4]

Some will sell their dreams for small desires
Or lose the race to rats, get caught in ticking traps
And start to dream of somewhere to relax their restless flight
Somewhere out of a memory of lighted streets on quiet nights

[CHORUS: GEDDY LEE & NEIL PEART]

(Subdivisions)—
In the high school halls in the shopping malls
Conform or be cast out
(Subdivisions)—
In the basement bars in the backs of cars
Be cool or be cast out

[GUITAR SOLO]

[POST-CHORUS]

Any escape might help to smooth the unattractive truth
But the suburbs have no charms to soothe the restless dreams of youth

[INSTRUMENTAL OUTRO]

Freewill

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Permanent Waves (1980), the song is notable for its demanding instrumental sections and intricate bass work. The lyric reflects themes that recur throughout Peart's writing: individual responsibility, skepticism toward dogma, and intellectual independence. "Freewill" argues for personal autonomy and responsibility. Rather than accepting fate, ideology, or social expectations as excuses, the narrator embraces the difficult freedom of making choices and accepting their consequences.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

There are those who think that
Life has nothing left to chance
A host of holy horrors
To direct our aimless dance

[PRE-CHORUS 1]

A planet of playthings, we dance on the strings
Of powers we cannot perceive
The stars aren't aligned or the gods are malign
Blame is better to give than receive

[CHORUS]

You can choose a ready guide in some celestial voice
If you choose not to decide, you still have made a choice
You can choose from phantom fears, and kindness that can kill
I will choose a path that's clear, I will choose free will

[VERSE 2]

There are those who think that
They've been dealt a losing hand
The cards were stacked against them
They weren't born in Lotus Land

[PRE-CHORUS 2]

All preordained, a prisoner in chains
A victim of venomous fate
Kicked in the face, you can pray for a place
In heaven's unearthly estate

[CHORUS]

You can choose a ready guide in some celestial voice
If you choose not to decide, you still have made a choice
You can choose from phantom fears and kindness that can kill
I will choose a path that's clear, I will choose free will

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK/GUITAR SOLO]

[PRE-CHORUS]

Each of us, a cell of awareness
Imperfect and incomplete
Genetic blends with uncertain ends
On a fortune hunt that's far too fleet

[CHORUS]

You can choose a ready guide in some celestial voice
If you choose not to decide, you still have made a choice
You can choose from phantom fears and kindness that can kill
I will choose a path that's clear, I will choose free will

Limelight

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

From Moving Pictures (1981), "Limelight" became one of Rush's signature songs. Peart drew partly on his own discomfort with celebrity, making it an unusually personal Rush lyric. A candid examination of fame and privacy. Peart contrasts the public image of a performer with the private person who may be uncomfortable with constant attention. The song's tension comes from the difference between performing for an audience and actually living under its gaze.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

Living on a lighted stage approaches the unreal
For those who think and feel
In touch with some reality beyond the gilded cage
Cast in this unlikely role, ill-equipped to act
With insufficient tact
One must put up barriers to keep oneself intact

[CHORUS]

Living in the limelight, the universal dream
For those who wish to seem
Those who wish to be must put aside the alienation
Get on with the fascination
The real relation, the underlying theme

[VERSE 2]

Living in a fisheye lens, caught in the camera eye
I have no heart to lie
I can't pretend a stranger is a long-awaited friend
All the world's indeed a stage, and we are merely players
Performers and portrayers
Each another's audience outside the gilded cage

[CHORUS]

Living in the limelight, the universal dream
For those who wish to seem
Those who wish to be must put aside the alienation
Get on with the fascination
The real relation, the underlying theme

[GUITAR SOLO]

[CHORUS]

Living in the limelight, the universal dream
For those who wish to seem
Those who wish to be must put aside the alienation
Get on with the fascination
The real relation, the underlying theme
The real relation, the underlying theme

Bravado

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Roll the Bones (1991), "Bravado" has become especially respected among fans for its concise, philosophical lyric. Its restrained arrangement contrasts with the grandiosity implied by the title. A reflection on risk, perseverance, and the possibility that effort may never produce the desired reward. The song treats courage not as guaranteed victory but as the willingness to commit despite uncertainty.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

If we burn our wings flying too close to the sun
If the moment of glory is over before it's begun

[CHORUS 1]

If the dream is won though everything is lost
We will pay the price, but we will not count the cost
We will pay the price, but we will not count the cost

[VERSE 2]

When the dust has cleared and victory denied
A summit too lofty, river a little too wide

[CHORUS 2]

If we keep our pride though paradise is lost
We will pay the price, but we will not count the cost
We will pay the price, but we will not count the cost
Oh

[GUITAR SOLO]

[VERSE 3]

And if the music stops, there's only the sound of the rain
All the hope and glory, all the sacrifice in vain

[CHORUS 3]

And if the love remains though everything is lost
We will pay the price, but we will not count the cost
We will pay the price, but we will not count the cost

[OUTRO]

And if the love remains though everything is lost
We will pay the price (We will pay the price)
But we will not count the cost (We will not count the cost)
And if the love remains (If the love remains)
Though everything is lost (Though everything is lost)
We will pay the price (We will pay the price)
But we will not count the cost (We will not count the cost)
And if the love remains

La Villa Strangiato

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Appearing on Hemispheres (1978), it was inspired by Alex Lifeson's dreams and by a comic-strip character. The recording is famous for its technical difficulty and became one of Rush's definitive instrumental showcases. An instrumental built around surreal, dreamlike images rather than a

conventional story. The title roughly means "The Strange Villa," and the piece translates the absurdity and vividness of a dream into a tightly structured musical journey.

LYRICS

[INSTRUMENTAL]

I. BUENAS NOCHES, MEIN FROINDS! (0:00–0:26)

II. To Sleep, Perchance to Dream... (0:27–1:59)

III. Strangiato Theme (2:00–3:15)

IV. A Lerxst in Wonderland (3:16–5:48)

V. Monsters! (5:49–6:09)

VI. The Ghost of the Aragon (6:10–6:44)

VII. Danforth and Pape (6:45–7:25)

VIII. The Waltz of the Shreves (7:26–7:51)

IX. Never Turn Your Back on a Monster! (7:52–8:02)

X. Monsters! (Reprise) (8:03–8:16)

XI. Strangiato Theme (Reprise) (8:17–9:20)

XII. A Farewell to Things (9:20–9:37)

Caravan

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released as a single in 2010 alongside "BU2B," it was among the first new Rush material previewing *Clockwork Angels* (2012). It helped introduce the album's futuristic and steampunk-influenced world. The song presents a restless fascination with the possibilities of technology, travel, and a world in motion. Its imagery evokes a future in which machines and human ambition continually push outward.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

In a world lit only by fire
A long train of flares
Under piercing stars
I stand watching the steam-liners roll by

[VERSE 2]

The caravan thunders onward
To the distant dream of the city
The caravan carries me onward
On my way at last, on my way at last

[CHORUS]

I can't stop thinking big
I can't stop thinking big
I can't stop thinking big
I can't stop thinking big

[VERSE 3]

On a road lit only by fire
Going where I want
Instead of where I should
I peer out at the passing shadows

[VERSE 4]

Carried through the night into the city
Where a young man has
A chance of making good
A chance to break from the past

[VERSE 5]

The caravan thunders onward
Stars winking through the canvas hood
The caravan thunders onward
On my way at last, on my way at last

[CHORUS]

I can't stop thinking big
I can't stop thinking big
I can't stop thinking big
I can't stop thinking big
I can't stop thinking big
I can't stop thinking big
In a world where I feel so small
I can't stop thinking big

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK]

[CHORUS]

I can't stop thinking big
I can't stop thinking big
I can't stop thinking big
I can't stop thinking big
I can't stop thinking big
I can't stop thinking big
In a world where I feel so small
I can't stop thinking big
(In a world where I feel so small
I can't stop thinking big)

Vital Signs

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

The closing track of Moving Pictures (1981), it demonstrates Rush's early-1980s blend of progressive ideas with reggae-influenced rhythm. It also became a favorite for listeners interested in the band's philosophical themes. A warning against losing individuality within social systems. The lyric uses biological and medical imagery to describe the tension between adapting to society and retaining an authentic identity.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

Unstable condition, a symptom of life
In mental and environmental change
Atmospheric disturbance, the feverish flux
Of human interface and interchange

[PRE-CHORUS]

The impulse is pure, sometimes our circuits get shorted
By external interference
Signals get crossed and the balance distorted
By internal incoherence

[CHORUS]

A tired mind become a shape-shifter
Everybody need a mood lifter
Everybody need reverse polarity
Everybody got mixed feelings
About the function and the form
Everybody got to deviate from the norm

[VERSE 2]

An ounce of perception, a pound of obscure
Process information at half speed
Pause, rewind, replay, warm memory chip
Random sample, hold the one you need

[PRE-CHORUS]

Leave out the fiction, the fact is, this friction
Will only be worn by persistence
Leave out conditions, courageous convictions
Will drag the dream into existence

[CHORUS]

A tired mind become a shape-shifter
Everybody need a soft filter
Everybody need reverse polarity
Everybody got mixed feelings
About the function and the form
Everybody got to elevate from the norm

[OUTRO]

Everybody got mixed feelings
Everybody got mixed feelings
Everybody got to deviate from the norm
Everybody got to deviate from the norm
Everybody got to elevate from the norm
Everybody got to elevate from the norm
Everybody got to elevate from the norm
Everybody got to elevate from the norm
Everybody got to escalate from the norm
Everybody got to elevate
Everybody got to elevate from the norm
Everybody got to deviate from the norm
Everybody got to deviate...

Distant Early Warning

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on *Grace Under Pressure* (1984), it reflects the geopolitical atmosphere of the era. The album as a whole was strongly shaped by Cold War tension and the anxieties of the nuclear age. The song explores Cold War anxiety, political brinkmanship, and the fear that ordinary people can be trapped beneath decisions made by powerful governments. Its title refers to the early-warning systems designed to detect incoming attacks.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

An ill wind comes arising across the cities of the plain
There's no swimming in the heavy water, no singing in the acid rain
Red alert, red alert
It's so hard to stay together, passing through revolving doors
We need someone to talk to and someone to sweep the floors
Incomplete, incomplete

[CHORUS]

The world weighs on my shoulders, but what am I to do?
You sometimes drive me crazy, but I worry about you
I know it makes no difference to what you're going through
But I see the tip of the iceberg and I worry about you

[VERSE 2]

Cruising under your radar, watching from the satellites
Take a page from the red book, keep them in your sights
Red alert, red alert
Left and rights of passage, black and whites of youth
Who can face the knowledge that the truth is not the truth?
Obsolete, absolute, yeah
Oh

[CHORUS]

The world weighs on my shoulders, but what am I to do?
You sometimes drive me crazy, but I worry about you
I know it makes no difference to what you're going through
But I see the tip of the iceberg and I worry about you

[GUITAR SOLO]

[CHORUS]

The world weighs on my shoulders, but what am I to do?
You sometimes drive me crazy, but I worry about you
I know it makes no difference to what you're going through
But I see the tip of the iceberg and I worry about you

[OUTRO]

Absalom, Absalom, Absalom

Red Sector A

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

From *Grace Under Pressure* (1984), the song was inspired by Peart's family history and Holocaust-related experiences of his parents. Its title also echoes the science-fictional language Rush often used to create distance around very real subjects. A fictionalized but emotionally grounded portrait of imprisonment, survival, and loss during wartime. The narrator remembers family members and confronts the dehumanizing conditions of a concentration camp.

LYRICS

[INTRO]

All that we can do is just survive
All that we can do to help ourselves is stay alive
All that we can do is just survive
All that we can do to help ourselves is stay alive

[VERSE 1]

Ragged lines of ragged grey
Skeletons, they shuffle away
Shouting guards and smoking guns
Will cut down the unlucky ones

[CHORUS 1]

I clutch the wire fence until my fingers bleed
A wound that will not heal, a heart that cannot feel
Hoping that the horror will recede
Hoping that tomorrow, we'll all be freed

[VERSE 2]

Sickness to insanity
Prayer to profanity
Days and weeks and months go by
Don't feel the hunger, too weak to cry

[CHORUS 2]

I hear the sound of gunfire at the prison gate
Are the liberators here? Do I hope or do I fear?
For my father and my brother, it's too late
But I must help my mother stand up straight

[POST-CHORUS]

Are we the last ones left alive?
Are we the only human beings to survive?
Are we the last ones left alive?
Are we the only human beings to survive?

[GUITAR SOLO]

[CHORUS]

I hear the sound of gunfire at the prison gate
Are the liberators here? Do I hope or do I fear?
For my father and my brother, it's too late
But I must help my mother stand up straight

[POST-CHORUS]

Are we the last ones left alive?
Are we the only human beings to survive?
Are we the last ones left alive?
Are we the only human beings to survive?

The Trees

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Hemispheres (1978), the song is often interpreted politically, although Peart resisted a single fixed allegorical reading. The comic-book-style story allowed Rush to explore class, hierarchy, and political conflict without naming a specific ideology. A fable about conflict between groups demanding equality and those resisting change. The trees argue over perceived advantages, but the attempt to impose fairness through force produces an even more absurd outcome.

LYRICS

[INTRO]

There is unrest in the forest, there is trouble with the trees
For the maples want more sunlight, and the oaks ignore their pleas

[VERSE 1]

The trouble with the maples, and they're quite convinced they're right
They say the oaks are just too lofty, and they grab up all the light
But the oaks can't help their feelings if they like the way they're made
And they wonder why the maples can't be happy in their shade

[BRIDGE]

There is trouble in the forest, and the creatures all have fled
As the maples scream, "Oppression!", and the oaks just shake their heads

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK]

[VERSE 2]

So the maples formed a union, and demanded equal rights
"The oaks are just too greedy, we will make them give us light"
Now there's no more oak oppression, for they passed a noble law
And the trees are all kept equal by hatchet, axe and saw

The Analog Kid

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Signals (1982), the song forms a thematic pairing with "Digital Man." Its title captures Rush's fascination with the transition from analog experience toward an increasingly computerized culture. A nostalgic contrast between youthful possibility and the increasingly digital, structured world around it. The narrator remembers the freedom of being young while sensing that modern life is becoming more technologically mediated.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

A hot and windy August afternoon has the trees in constant motion
With a flash of silver leaves, as they're rocking in the breeze
The boy lies in the grass with one blade stuck between his teeth
A vague sensation quickens in his young and restless heart
And a bright and nameless vision has him longing to depart

[CHORUS]

You move me, you move me
With your buildings and your eyes, autumn woods and winter skies
You move me, you move me
Open sea and city lights, busy streets and dizzy heights
You call me, you call me

[VERSE 2]

The fawn-eyed girl with sun-browned legs dances on the edge of his dream
And her voice rings in his ears, like the music of the spheres
The boy lies in the grass, unmoving, staring at the sky
His mother starts to call him as a hawk goes soaring by
And the boy pulls down his baseball cap and covers up his eyes

[CHORUS]

You move me, you move me
With your buildings and your eyes, autumn woods and winter skies
You move me, you move me
Open sea and city lights, busy streets and dizzy heights
You call me, you call me

[BRIDGE]

Too many hands on my time, too many feelings
Too many things on my mind
When I leave, I don't know what I'm hoping to find
And when I leave, I don't know what I'm leaving behind

[GUITAR SOLO]

[OUTRO]

When I leave, I don't know what I'm hoping to find
And when I leave, I don't know what I'm leaving behind

Leave That Thing Alone

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Counterparts (1993), it became one of Rush's notable later instrumentals. The track earned a Grammy nomination for Best Rock Instrumental Performance. An instrumental centered on groove, texture, and interplay rather than a narrative. It suggests the attitude of the title through its playful, slightly mysterious musical character.

LYRICS

[INSTRUMENTAL]

Headlong Flight

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Clockwork Angels (2012), it became one of Rush's major late-period concert songs. The extended instrumental section gave the band an opportunity to revisit its progressive-rock roots. A celebration of a life fully lived, including mistakes, adventures, disappointments, and triumphs. Instead of wishing for a cleaner or safer past, the narrator embraces the whole journey.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

All the journeys of this great adventure
It didn't always feel that way
I wouldn't trade them because I made them
The best I could, and that's enough to say

[REFRAIN]

Some days were dark
I wish that I could live it all again
Some nights were bright
I wish that I could live it all again

[VERSE 2]

All the highlights of that headlong flight
Holding on with all my might
To what I felt back then
I wish that I could live it all again

[CHORUS]

I have stoked the fire on the big steel wheels
Steered the airship right across the stars
I learned to fight, I learned to love, I learned to feel
Oh, I wish that I could live it all again

[VERSE 3]

All the treasures, the gold and glory
It didn't always feel that way
I don't regret it, I'll never forget it
I wouldn't trade tomorrow for today

[REFRAIN]

Some days were dark
I wish that I could live it all again
Some nights were bright
I wish that I could live it all again

[CHORUS]

I have stoked the fire on the big steel wheels
Steered the airship right across the stars
I learned to fight, I learned to love, I learned to feel
Oh, I wish that I could live it all again

[INTERLUDE (SPOKEN)]

The days were dark
And the nights were bright
Hey, man, I would never trade tomorrow for today

[DRUM BREAK]

[GUITAR SOLO]

[VERSE 4]

All the highlights of that headlong flight
Holding on with all my might

[REFRAIN]

Some days were dark
I wish that I could live it all again
Some nights were bright
I wish that I could live it all again

[CHORUS]

I have stoked the fire on the big steel wheels
Steered the airship right across the stars
I learned to fight, I learned to love, I learned to feel
Oh, I wish that I could live it all again

[CHORUS]

I have stoked the fire on the big steel wheels
Steered the airship right across the stars
I learned to fight, I learned to love, I learned to steal
Oh, I wish that I could
Oh, I wish that I could live it all again

New World Man

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

From *Signals* (1982), it became Rush's highest-charting U.S. single, reaching the Top 40. The song helped demonstrate how the band could integrate synthesizers and shorter song structures without abandoning its intellectual themes. A portrait of a self-directed modern individual who rejects inherited assumptions and seeks to create his own identity. It combines optimism about change with a recognition that modern life can be disorienting.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

He's a rebel and a runner, he's a signal turning green
He's a restless, young romantic, wants to run the big machine
He's got a problem with his poisons, but you know he'll find a cure
He's cleaning up his systems to keep his nature pure

[PRE-CHORUS]

Learning to match the beat of the Old World Man
Learning to catch the heat of the Third World Man

[CHORUS 1]

He's got to make his own mistakes and learn to mend the mess he makes
He's old enough to know what's right, but young enough not to choose it
He's noble enough to win the world, but weak enough to lose it
He's a New World Man

[VERSE 2]

He's a radio receiver, tuned to factories and farms
He's a writer and a ranger and a young boy bearing arms
He's got a problem with his power, with weapons on patrol
He's got to walk a fine line and keep his self-control

[PRE-CHORUS]

Trying to save the day for the Old World Man
Trying to pave the way for the Third World Man

[CHORUS 2]

He's not concerned with yesterday, he knows constant change is here today
He's noble enough to know what's right, but weak enough not to choose it
He's wise enough to win the world, but fool enough to lose it
He's a New World Man

[OUTRO]

Learning to match the beat of the Old World Man
He's learning to catch the heat of the Third World Man
He's a New World Man
He's a New World Man

The Pass

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Presto (1989), "The Pass" is one of Peart's most direct and empathetic lyrics. Rush later discussed its importance in connecting with listeners who had experienced depression or suicidal thoughts. A compassionate song about despair, alienation, and suicide prevention. Rather than romanticizing hopelessness, it argues that a person's darkest moment does not have to determine the rest of their life.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

Proud swagger out of the schoolyard
Waiting for the world's applause
Rebel without a conscience
Martyr without a cause
Static on your frequency
Electrical storm in your veins
Raging at unreachable glory
Straining at invisible chains

[PRE-CHORUS]

And now you're trembling on a rocky ledge
Staring down into a heartless sea
Can't face life on a razor's edge
Nothing's what you thought it would be

[CHORUS]

All of us get lost in the darkness
Dreamers learn to steer by the stars
All of us do time in the gutter
Dreamers turn to look at the cars
Turn around and turn around and turn around
Turn around and walk the razor's edge
Don't turn your back and slam the door on me

[VERSE 2]

It's not as if this barricade
Blocks the only road
It's not as if you're all alone
In wanting to explode
Someone set a bad example
Made surrender seem all right
The act of a noble warrior
Who lost the will to fight

[PRE-CHORUS]

And now you're trembling on a rocky ledge
Staring down into a heartless sea
Done with life on a razor's edge
Nothing's what you thought it would be

[CHORUS]

All of us get lost in the darkness
Dreamers learn to steer by the stars
All of us do time in the gutter
Dreamers turn to look at the cars
Turn around and turn around and turn around
Turn around and walk the razor's edge
Don't turn your back and slam the door on me

[GUITAR SOLO]

[BRIDGE]

No hero in your tragedy
No daring in your escape
No salutes for your surrender
Nothing noble in your fate
Christ, what have you done?

[CHORUS]

All of us get lost in the darkness
Dreamers learn to steer by the stars
All of us do time in the gutter
Dreamers turn to look at the cars
Turn around and turn around and turn around
Turn around and walk the razor's edge
Turn around and walk the razor's edge
Turn around and walk the razor's edge
Don't turn your back and slam the door on me

The Anarchist

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on *Clockwork Angels* (2012), the song is part of Rush's late-career return to more ambitious narrative and philosophical material. Its darker tone fits the album's larger examination of freedom and control. A character study of someone who rejects social conventions and lives by a personal code, but whose isolation carries a cost. The song questions whether radical independence is liberating when it becomes detached from human connection.

LYRICS

[INTRO]

(What do you lack?)
(What do you lack?)

[VERSE 1]

Will there be world enough and time for me to sing that song?
A voice so silent for so long
For all those years I had to get along, they told me I was wrong
I never wanted to belong, I was so strong!

[PRE-CHORUS]

I lack their smiles and their diamonds
I lack their happiness and love
I envy them for all those things
I never got my fair share of, my fair share of

[CHORUS]

The lenses inside of me that paint the world black
The pools of poison, the scarlet mist, that spill over into rage
The things I've always been denied
An early promise that somehow died
A missing part of me that grows around me like a cage
A missing part of me that grows around me like a cage

[VERSE 2]

In all your science of the mind, seeking blind through flesh and bone
Find the blood inside this stone
What I know, I've never shown; what I feel, I've always known
I plan my vengeance on my own, and I was always alone

[PRE-CHORUS]

I lack their smiles and their diamonds
I lack their happiness and love
I envy them for all those things
I never got my fair share of, my fair share of

[CHORUS]

The lenses inside of me that paint the world black
The pools of poison, the scarlet mist, that spill over into rage
The things I've always been denied
An early promise that somehow died
A missing part of me that grows around me like a cage
A missing part of me that grows around me like a cage

[BRIDGE]

Oh, they tried to get me
Oh, they'll never forget me

[GUITAR SOLO]

[CHORUS]

The lenses inside of me that paint the world black
The pools of poison, the scarlet mist, that spill over into rage
The things I've always been denied
An early promise that somehow died
A missing part of me that grows around me like a cage
A missing part of me that grows around me like a cage
A missing part of me that grows around me like a cage

The Camera Eye

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

The longest track on *Moving Pictures* (1981), it was inspired in part by the urban observations of J.G. Ballard. The piece is notable for its extended instrumental architecture and synthesizer textures. A panoramic observation of modern cities and the people moving through them. The narrator acts like a camera, recording the rhythm, anonymity, energy, and contradictions of urban life without fully participating.

LYRICS

[INSTRUMENTAL INTRO]

[VERSE 1]

Grim faced and forbidding, their faces closed tight
An angular mass of New Yorkers
Pacing in rhythm, race the oncoming night
They chase through the streets of Manhattan
Head first humanity, pause at a light
Then flow through the streets of the city

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK]

[PRE-CHORUS]

They seem oblivious to a soft spring rain, like an English rain
So light, yet endless, from a leaden sky, yeah
The buildings are lost in their limitless rise
My feet catch the pulse and the purposeful stride

[CHORUS]

I feel the sense of possibilities
I feel the wrench of hard realities
The focus is sharp in the city

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK]

[VERSE 2]

Wide angle watcher on life's ancient tales
Steeped in the history of London
Green and grey washes in a wispy white veil
Mist in the streets of Westminster
Wistful and weathered, the pride still prevails
Alive in the streets of the city

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK]

[PRE-CHORUS]

Are they oblivious to this quality? A quality
Of light unique to every city's streets
("Hello!"
"Morning, guv.")
Pavements may teem with intense energy
But the city is calm in this violent sea

[GUITAR SOLO]

[CHORUS]

I feel the sense of possibilities
I feel the wrench of hard realities
The focus is sharp in the city

Far Cry

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Snakes & Arrows (2007), it became a prominent late-period Rush song and a regular part of the band's live sets. Its title captures the distance between idealized expectations and lived experience. A song about contradiction: the gap between how people imagine the world should be and how chaotic reality actually is. It embraces uncertainty while acknowledging that modern life contains both astonishing progress and persistent dysfunction.

LYRICS

[INSTRUMENTAL INTRO]

[VERSE 1]

Pariah dogs and wandering madmen
Barking at strangers and speaking in tongues
The ebb and flow of tidal fortune
Electrical changes are charging up the young

[PRE-CHORUS]

(Ooh-hoo) It's a far cry from the world we thought we'd inherit
(Ooh-hoo) It's a far cry from the way we thought we'd share it
(Ooh-hoo) You can almost feel the current flowing
You can almost see the circuits blowing

[CHORUS]

One day, I feel I'm on top of the world, and the next, it's falling in on me
I can get back on, I can get back on
One day, I feel I'm ahead of the wheel, and the next, it's rolling over me
I can get back on, I can get back on

[VERSE 2]

Whirlwind life of faith and betrayal
Rise in anger, fall back, and repeat
Slow degrees on the dark horizon
Full moon rising lays silver at your feet

[PRE-CHORUS]

(Ooh-hoo) It's a far cry from the world we thought we'd inherit
(Ooh-hoo) It's a far cry from the way we thought we'd share it
(Ooh-hoo) You can almost feel the current flowing
You can almost see the circuits blowing

[CHORUS]

One day, I feel I'm on top of the world, and the next, it's falling in on me
I can get back on, I can get back on
One day, I feel I'm ahead of the wheel, and the next, it's rolling over me
I can get back on, I can get back on

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK]

[PRE-CHORUS]

It's a far cry from the world we thought we'd inherit
You can almost see the circle growing
You can almost feel the planets glowing

[CHORUS]

One day, I feel I'm on top of the world, and the next, it's falling in on me
I can get back on, I can get back on
One day, I feel I'm ahead of the wheel, and the next, it's rolling over me
I can get back on, I can get back on

[POST-CHORUS]

One day, I fly through a crack in the sky, and the next, it's falling in on me
I can get back on, I can get back on
Oh, I can get back on, I can get back on

Dreamline

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

The opening track of *Roll the Bones* (1991), it became one of the band's strongest live songs from the 1990s. Its imagery reflects Peart's lifelong fascination with travel and motion. An energetic celebration of travel, possibility, and the refusal to wait for life to begin. The narrator imagines crossing boundaries and pursuing experience before time runs out.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

He's got a road map of Jupiter
A radar fix on the stars
All along the highway
She's got a liquid-crystal compass
A picture book of the rivers
Under the Sahara

[CHORUS 1]

They travel in the time of the prophets
On a desert highway straight to the heart of the sun
Like lovers and heroes, and the restless part of everyone
We're only at home when we're on the run
On the run

[VERSE 2]

He's got a star map of Hollywood
A list of cheap motels
All along the freeway
She's got a sister out in Vegas
The promise of a decent job
Far away from her hometown

[CHORUS 1]

They travel on the road to redemption
A highway out of yesterday -- that tomorrow will bring
Like lovers and heroes, birds in the last days of spring
We're only at home when we're on the wing
On the wing

[CHORUS 2]

We are young
Wandering the face of the Earth
Wondering what our dreams might be worth
Learning that we're only immortal
For a limited time
We are young
Wandering the face of the Earth
Wondering what our dreams might be worth
Learning that we're only immortal
For a limited time

[VERSE 3]

Time is a gypsy caravan
Steals away in the night
To leave you stranded in Dreamland
Distance is a long-range filter
Memory a flickering light
Left behind in the heartland

[CHORUS 1]

We travel in the dark of the new moon
A starry highway traced on the map of the sky
Like lovers and heroes, lonely as the eagle's cry
We're only at home when we're on the fly
On the fly

[GUITAR SOLO]

[CHORUS 2]

We are young
Wandering the face of the Earth
Wondering what our dreams might be worth
Learning that we're only immortal
For a limited time
We are young
Wandering the face of the Earth
Wondering what our dreams might be worth
Learning that we're only immortal
For a limited time
When we are young
Wandering the face of the Earth
Wondering what our dreams might be worth
Learning that we're only immortal
For a limited time

[CHORUS 1]

We travel on the road to adventure
On a desert highway straight to the heart of the sun
Like lovers and heroes, and the restless part of everyone
We're only at home when we're on the run
On the run

Natural Science

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

The closing track of *Permanent Waves* (1980), it is one of Rush's classic long-form compositions. The song's three sections—"Tide Pools," "Hyperspace," and "Permanent Waves"—combine science imagery with philosophical reflection. A three-part philosophical exploration of nature, human civilization, and the tension between order and chaos. It ultimately questions humanity's assumption that it can completely understand or control the systems in which it exists.

LYRICS

[I. TIDE POOLS]

[VERSE 1]

When the ebbing tide retreats
Along the rocky shoreline
It leaves a trail of tidal pools
In a short-lived galaxy
Each microcosmic planet
A complete society

[VERSE 2]

A simple kind mirror
To reflect upon our own
All the busy little creatures
Chasing out their destinies
Living in their pools
They soon forget about the sea...

[INSTRUMENTAL REFRAIN]

[CHORUS]

Wheels within wheels in a spiral array
A pattern so grand and complex
Time after time we lose sight of the way
Our causes can't see their effects

[II. HYPERSPACE]

[VERSE 3]

A quantum leap forward
In time and in space
The universe learned to expand
The mess and the magic
Triumphant and tragic
A mechanized world out of hand

[INSTRUMENTAL REFRAIN]

[VERSE 4]

Computerized clinic
For superior cynics
Who dance to a synthetic band
In their own image
Their world is fashioned
No wonder they don't understand

[GUITAR SOLO]

[CHORUS]

Wheels within wheels in a spiral array
A pattern so grand and complex
Time after time we lose sight of the way
Our causes can't see their effects

[III. PERMANENT WAVES]

[VERSE 5]

Science, like nature, must also be tamed
With a view towards its preservation
Given the same state of integrity
It will surely serve us well

[VERSE 6]

Art as expression, not as market campaigns
Will still capture our imaginations
Given the same state of integrity
It will surely help us along

[GUITAR SOLO]

[VERSE 7]

The most endangered species: the honest man
Will still survive annihilation
Forming a world, state of integrity
Sensitive, open and strong

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK]

[VERSE 8]

Wave after wave will flow with the tide
And bury the world as it does
Tide after tide will flow and recede
Leaving life to go on as it was

[INSTRUMENTAL OUTRO]

Anthem

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Fly by Night (1975), it is one of Neil Peart's earliest Rush lyrics. Its title and themes foreshadow ideas that would later be expanded dramatically in "2112." An early statement of individualism and resistance to collectivist thinking. The song argues that personal achievement and independent thought should not be subordinated to demands for uniformity.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

Know your place in life is where you want to be
Don't let them tell you that you owe it all to me
Keep on looking forward, no use in looking 'round
Hold your head above the crowd and they won't bring you down

[CHORUS]

Anthem of the heart and anthem of the mind
A funeral dirge for eyes gone blind
We marvel after those who sought
Wonders in the world, wonders in the world
Wonders in the world they wrought!

[VERSE 2]

Live for yourself
There's no one else more worth living for
Begging hands and bleeding hearts
Will only cry out for more

[CHORUS]

Anthem of the heart and anthem of the mind
A funeral dirge for eyes gone blind
We marvel after those who sought
Wonders in the world, wonders in the world
Wonders in the world they wrought!

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK]

[GUITAR SOLO]

[VERSE 3]

Well, I know they've always told you
Selfishness was wrong
Yet it was for me, not you
I came to write this song

[CHORUS]

Anthem of the heart and anthem of the mind
A funeral dirge for eyes gone blind
We marvel after those who sought
Wonders in the world, wonders in the world
Wonders in the world they wrought!
Wrought!
Wrought!

2112

SET TWO OPENER

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

A science-fiction story about an individual discovering music in a society where the ruling Priests control culture and suppress independent expression. At its core, the suite is about creativity, freedom, conformity, and the danger of centralized control over thought. Released in 1976, 2112 was Rush's commercial breakthrough despite pressure from the record label to make more conventional music. The title suite occupies roughly one side of the original album and was influenced by Ayn Rand's Anthem as well as broader science fiction.

LYRICS

[PART I: OVERTURE (0:00–4:31)]

[INSTRUMENTAL]

[OUTRO]

And the meek shall inherit the earth

[PART II: THE TEMPLES OF SYRINX (4:31–6:47)]

[VERSE 1]

We've taken care of everything
The words you read, the songs you sing
The pictures that give pleasure to your eye
It's one for all and all for one
We work together, common son
Never need to wonder how or why

[CHORUS]

We are the Priests of the Temples of Syrinx
Our great computers fill the hallowed halls
We are the Priests of the Temples of Syrinx
All the gifts of life are held within our walls

[VERSE 2]

Look around at this world we've made
Equality, our stock-in-trade
Come and join the Brotherhood of Man
Oh, what a nice, contented world
Let the banners be unfurled
Hold the Red Star proudly high in hand

[CHORUS]

We are the Priests of the Temples of Syrinx
Our great computers fill the hallowed halls
We are the Priests of the Temples of Syrinx
All the gifts of life are held within our walls

[PART III: DISCOVERY (6:47–10:15)]

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK]

[VERSE 1]

What can this strange device be?
When I touch it, it gives forth a sound
It's got wires that vibrate and give music
What can this thing be that I found?

[VERSE 2]

See how it sings like a sad heart
And joyously screams out its pain
Sounds that build high like a mountain
Or notes that fall gently like rain

[VERSE 3]

I can't wait to share this new wonder
The people will all see its light
Let them all make their own music
The Priests praise my name on this night

[PART IV: PRESENTATION (10:15–13:57)]

[VERSE 1]

I know it's most unusual to come before you so
But I've found an ancient miracle
I thought that you should know
Listen to my music and hear what it can do
There's something here as strong as life
I know that it will reach you

[VERSE 2]

Yes, we know, it's nothing new
It's just a waste of time
We have no need for ancient ways, our world is doing fine
Another toy that helped destroy the elder race of man
Forget about your silly whim, it doesn't fit the plan, no!

[VERSE 3]

I can't believe you're saying these things just can't be true
Our world could use this beauty, just think what we might do
Listen to my music and hear what it can do
There's something here that's as strong as life
I know that it will reach you

[VERSE 4]

Don't annoy us further!
Oh, we have our work to do
Just think about the average, what use have they for you?
Another toy that helped destroy the elder race of man
Forget about your silly whim, it doesn't fit the plan!

[GUITAR SOLO]

[PART V: ORACLE: THE DREAM (13:57–15:57)]

[VERSE 1]

I wandered home through silent streets
And fell into a fitful sleep
Escape to realms beyond the night
Dream, can't you show me the light?

[VERSE 2]

I stand atop a spiral stair
An oracle confronts me there
He leads me on light years away
Through astral nights, galactic days
I see the works of gifted hands
That grace this strange and wondrous land
I see the hand of man arise
With hungry mind and open eyes

[VERSE 3]

They left our planets long ago
The elder race still learn and grow
Their power grows with purpose strong
To claim the home where they belong
Home to tear the Temples down, home to change!

[PART VI: SOLILOQUY (15:57–18:19)]

[VERSE 1]

The sleep is still in my eyes, the dream is still in my head
I heave a sigh and sadly smile and lie awhile in bed
I wish that it might come to pass, not fade like all my dreams

[VERSE 2]

Just think of what my life might be in a world like I have seen!
I don't think I can carry on, carry on this cold and empty life
Oh, no!

[GUITAR SOLO]

[VERSE 3]

My spirits are low in the depths of despair
My lifeblood spills over

[PART VII: GRAND FINALE (18:19–20:33)]

[INSTRUMENTAL]

[OUTRO]

Attention all Planets of the Solar Federation
Attention all Planets of the Solar Federation
Attention all Planets of the Solar Federation
We have assumed control
We have assumed control
We have assumed control

Animate

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Counterparts (1993), the song reflects Peart's interest in psychology and archetypal ideas. It became one of the band's most recognizable songs from the 1990s. A meditation on identity, gendered archetypes, and the competing forces within a person. The lyric treats different aspects of personality almost as characters or energies that need to coexist.

LYRICS

[INTRO]

One, two, three, four, one, two

[CHORUS]

Polarize me, sensitize me
Criticize me, civilize me
Compensate me, animate me
Complicate me, elevate me

[VERSE 1]

Goddess in my garden, sister in my soul
Angel in my armor, actress in my role
Daughter of a demon-lover, empress of the hidden face
Priestess of the pagan mother, ancient queen of inner space

[CHORUS]

Polarize me, sensitize me
Criticize me, civilize me
Compensate me, animate me
Complicate me, elevate me

[VERSE 2]

Spirit in my psyche, double in my role
Alter in my image, struggle for control
Mistress of the dark unconscious, mermaid of the lunar sea
Daughter of the great enchantress, sister to the boy inside of me

[CHORUS]

Polarize me, sensitize me
Criticize me, civilize me
Compensate me, animate me
Complicate me, elevate me

[BRIDGE]

My counterpart, my foolish heart
A man must learn to rule his tender part
A warming trend, a gentle friend
A man must build a fortress to defend

[GUITAR SOLO]

[BRIDGE]

A secret face, a touch of grace
A man must learn to give a little space
A peaceful state, a submissive trait
A man must learn to gently dominate

[CHORUS]

Polarize me, sensitize me
Criticize me, civilize me
Compensate me, animate me
Complicate me, elevate me
Complicate me, elevate me, ohh!

Closer to the Heart

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on *A Farewell to Kings* (1977), it became one of Rush's most accessible and enduring songs. Its collaborative lyric credits reflect the involvement of lyricist Peter Talbot alongside Peart. A hopeful appeal for people to take responsibility for shaping society. Rather than waiting for institutions or leaders to change the world, the song suggests that individuals can contribute by acting with compassion and purpose.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

And the men who hold high places
Must be the ones who start
To mold a new reality

[CHORUS]

Closer to the heart
Closer to the heart

[VERSE 2]

The blacksmith and the artist
Reflect it in their art
They forge their creativity

[CHORUS]

Closer to the heart
Yes, closer to the heart

[VERSE 3]

Philosophers and ploughmen
Each must know his part
To sow a new mentality

[CHORUS]

Closer to the heart
Yes, closer to the heart
Yeah
Woah

[GUITAR SOLO]

[VERSE 4]

Woah, woah, you can be the captain
And I will draw the chart
Sailing into destiny

[CHORUS]

Closer to the heart
Closer to the heart

[OUTRO]

Well, closer to the heart
Yeah, closer to the heart
Closer to the heart
I said, closer to the heart
Well, closer to the heart
Yeah, closer to your heart
Closer to your heart
Woah

A Passage to Bangkok

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on 2112 (1976), Geddy Lee later described it as essentially a song about smoking marijuana and visiting places known for it.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

Our first stop is in Bogotá
To check Colombian fields
The natives smile and pass along
A sample of their yield
Sweet Jamaican pipe dreams
Golden Acapulco nights
Then Morocco, and the East
Fly by morning light

[CHORUS]

We're on the train to Bangkok
Aboard the Thailand Express
We'll hit the stops along the way
We only stop for the best

[VERSE 2]

Wreathed in smoke in Lebanon
We burn the midnight oil
The fragrance of Afghanistan
Rewards a long day's toil
Pulling into Kathmandu
Smoke rings fill the air
Perfumed by a Nepal night
The Express gets you there

[CHORUS]

We're on the train to Bangkok
Aboard the Thailand Express
We'll hit the stops along the way
We only stop for the best

[GUITAR SOLO]

[CHORUS]

We're on the train to Bangkok
Aboard the Thailand Express
We'll hit the stops along the way
We only stop for the best
Yes, we're on the train to Bangkok
Aboard the Thailand Express
We'll hit the stops along the way
We only stop for the best

Time Stand Still

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Hold Your Fire (1987), it features backing vocals from Aimee Mann. The song became especially resonant as Rush's audience aged, turning a personal reflection on time into one of the band's most emotionally direct songs. A plea to slow down and appreciate fleeting moments rather than constantly rushing toward the next goal. The song captures the bittersweet realization that experiences, relationships, and youth cannot be permanently preserved.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1: GEDDY LEE]

I turn my back to the wind
To catch my breath before I start off again
Driven on without a moment to spend
To pass an evening with a drink and a friend
I let my skin get too thin
I'd like to pause, no matter what I pretend
Like some pilgrim who learns to transcend
Learns to live as if each step was the end

[PRE-CHORUS: AIMEE MANN & GEDDY LEE]

Time stand still
I'm not looking back, but I want to look around me now
Time stand still
See more of the people and the places that surround me now
Time stand still

[CHORUS: GEDDY LEE]

Freeze this moment a little bit longer
Make each sensation a little bit stronger
Experience slips away
Experience slips away
Time stand still

[VERSE 2: GEDDY LEE]

I turn my face to the sun
Close my eyes, let my defences down
All those wounds that I can't get unwound
I let my past go too fast
No time to pause, if I could slow it all down
Like some captain whose ship runs aground
I can wait until the tide comes around

[PRE-CHORUS: AIMEE MANN & GEDDY LEE]

Time stand still
I'm not looking back, but I want to look around me now
Time stand still
See more of the people and the places that surround me now

[CHORUS: GEDDY LEE]

Freeze this moment a little bit longer
Make each sensation a little bit stronger
Make each impression a little bit stronger
Freeze this motion a little bit longer
The innocence slips away
The innocence slips away
Time stand still
Time stand still

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK]

[PRE-CHORUS: GEDDY LEE]

I'm not looking back, but I want to look around me now
See more of the people and the places that surround me now
Time stand still

[CHORUS: GEDDY LEE]

Summer's going fast, nights growing colder
Children growing up, old friends growing older
Freeze this moment a little bit longer
Make each sensation a little bit stronger
Experience slips away
Experience slips away
The innocence slips away

YYZ

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Moving Pictures (1981), it became one of Rush's signature instrumental performances. The song was Grammy-nominated for Best Rock Instrumental Performance. An instrumental built around the excitement and rhythm of travel. Its title comes from the IATA airport code for Toronto Pearson International Airport, and the opening rhythm translates the Morse-code pattern for Y-Y-Z into music.

LYRICS

[INSTRUMENTAL]

Red Barchetta

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

From Moving Pictures (1981), the song was inspired by Richard Foster's short story "A Nice Morning Drive." Its vivid narrative helped make it a favorite among Rush fans and car enthusiasts. A futuristic chase story in which a young driver escapes into the countryside and races an old sports car while evading authorities. It celebrates mechanical freedom, independence, and the thrill of driving.

LYRICS

[INSTRUMENTAL INTRO]

[VERSE 1]

My uncle has a country place that no one knows about
He says it used to be a farm before the Motor Law
And on Sundays, I elude the eyes and hop the turbine freight
To far outside the wire where my white-haired uncle waits

[CHORUS]

Jump to the ground, as the Turbo slows to cross the borderline
Run like the wind, as excitement shivers up and down my spine
Down in his barn, my uncle preserved for me an old machine
For fifty-odd years, to keep it as new has been his dearest dream

[VERSE 2]

I strip away the old debris, that hides a shining car
A brilliant red Barchetta, from a better, vanished time
We fire up the willing engine, responding with a roar
Tires spitting gravel, I commit my weekly crime

[BRIDGE]

Wind in my hair
Shifting and drifting
Mechanical music
Adrenaline surge
Well-weathered leather, hot metal and oil
The scented country air
Sunlight on chrome, the blur of the landscape
Every nerve aware

[GUITAR SOLO]

[VERSE 3]

Suddenly, ahead of me across the mountainside
A gleaming alloy air-car shoots towards me, two lanes wide
I spin around with shrieking tires to run the deadly race
Go screaming through the valley, as another joins the chase

[CHORUS]

Drive like the wind, straining the limits of machine and man
Laughing out loud with fear and hope, I've got a desperate plan
At the one-lane bridge, I leave the giants stranded at the riverside
Race back to the farm to dream with my uncle at the fireside

[INSTRUMENTAL OUTRO]

The Garden

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

The closing song on *Clockwork Angels* (2012), it provides a quiet, philosophical conclusion to Rush's final studio album. Its orchestral arrangement and restrained performance give it an elegiac quality. A reflective meditation on mortality, legacy, and the idea that a meaningful life is measured by what one cultivates rather than what one accumulates. The garden becomes a metaphor for the life each person creates.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

In this one of many possible worlds
All for the best, or some bizarre test
It is what it is, and whatever
Time is still the infinite jest

[PRE-CHORUS]

The arrow flies when you dream;
The hours tick away
The cells tick away
The Watchmaker keeps to his schemes
The hours tick away
They tick away

[CHORUS]

The measure of a life is a measure of love and respect;
So hard to earn, so easily burned
The measure of a life is a measure of love and respect;
So hard to earn, so easily burned
In the fullness of time
A garden to nurture and protect

[VERSE 2]

In the rise and the set of the sun
Till the stars go spinning, spinning 'round the night
Oh, it is what it is, and forever;
Each moment, a memory in flight

[PRE-CHORUS]

The arrow flies while you breathe;
The hours tick away
The cells tick away
The Watchmaker has time up his sleeve
The hours tick away
They tick away

[CHORUS]

The measure of a life is a measure of love and respect;
So hard to earn, so easily burned
In the fullness of time
A garden to nurture and protect
(It's a measure of a life)
The treasure of a life is a measure of love and respect:
The way you live, the gifts that you give
In the fullness of time
Is the only return that you expect

[BRIDGE]

The future disappears into memory
With only a moment between
Forever dwells in that moment;
Hope is what remains to be seen
Forever dwells in that moment;
Hope is what remains to be seen

[GUITAR SOLO]

[OUTRO]

In the fullness of time
A garden to nurture and protect
(It's a measure of a life)
In the fullness of time
A garden to nurture and protect
(It's a measure of a life)
In the fullness of time
A garden to nurture and protect
(It's a measure of a life)
In the fullness of time
A garden to nurture and protect
(It's a measure of a life)
(It's a measure of a life)
(It's a measure of a life)
(It's a measure of a life)

Tom Sawyer

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Moving Pictures (1981), it became perhaps Rush's most famous song. The lyric was co-written with Pye Dubois and the music combines a highly recognizable synthesizer opening with complex instrumental sections. A portrait of an independent-minded modern person who resists being reduced to social categories. The character is confident, observant, and unwilling to let institutions define his identity.

LYRICS

[INTRO]

A modern-day warrior
Mean, mean stride
Today's Tom Sawyer
Mean, mean pride

[VERSE 1]

Though his mind is not for rent
Don't put him down as arrogant
His reserve a quiet defense
Riding out the day's events
The river

[CHORUS]

What you say about his company
Is what you say about society
Catch the mist
Catch the myth
Catch the mystery
Catch the drift

[BRIDGE]

The world is, the world is
Love and life are deep
Maybe as his skies are wide
Today's Tom Sawyer, he gets high on you
And the space he invades, he gets by on you

[INSTRUMENTAL]

[VERSE 2]

No, his mind is not for rent
To any god or government
Always hopeful, yet discontent
He knows changes aren't permanent
But change is

[CHORUS]

And what you say about his company
Is what you say about society
Catch the witness
Catch the wit
Catch the spirit
Catch the spit

[REFRAIN]

The world is, the world is
Love and life are deep
Maybe as his eyes are wide

[OUTRO]

Exit the warrior
Today's Tom Sawyer
He gets high on you
And the energy you trade
He gets right on to
The friction of the day

Witch Hunt

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Moving Pictures (1981), it is the third part of the informal "Fear" sequence, though it was recorded as the first part. Its ominous spoken voices and atmospheric arrangement make it one of Rush's darkest tracks. A condemnation of mob mentality and the tendency of frightened societies to demonize outsiders. The song shows how fear, propaganda, and groupthink can turn ordinary people into persecutors.

LYRICS

[INSTRUMENTAL INTRO]

[VERSE 1]

The night is black, without a moon
The air is thick and still
The vigilantes gather on
The lonely torch-lit hill

[VERSE 2]

Features distorted in the flickering light
Faces are twisted and grotesque
Silent and stern in the sweltering night
The mob moves like demons possessed
Quiet in conscience, calm in their right
Confident their ways are best
Oh, ohhh

[VERSE 3]

The righteous rise with burning eyes
Of hatred and ill-will
Madmen fed on fear and lies
To beat and burn and kill

[VERSE 4]

They say there are strangers who threaten us
Our immigrants and infidels
They say there is strangeness too dangerous
In our theatres and bookstore shelves
Those who know what's best for us
Must rise and save us from ourselves

[OUTRO]

Quick to judge, quick to anger
Slow to understand
Ignorance and prejudice
And fear walk hand in hand

A Farewell to Kings

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

The title track of A Farewell to Kings (1977), it helped introduce the album's more elaborate progressive style. The title was influenced by Ernest Hemingway's A Farewell to Arms. A critique of political corruption and the disappointment that follows when leaders fail to live up to ideals. The narrator imagines a society in which citizens have become cynical about authority.

LYRICS

[INSTRUMENTAL INTRO]

[VERSE 1]

When they turn the pages of history, when these days have passed long ago
Will they read of us with sadness for the seeds that we let grow?
We turned our gaze from the castles in the distance
Eyes cast down on the path of least resistance

[CHORUS]

Cities full of hatred, fear and lies
Withered hearts and cruel, tormented eyes
Scheming demons dressed in kingly guise
Beating down the multitude and scoffing at the wise

[VERSE 2]

The hypocrites are slandering the sacred halls of Truth
Ancient nobles showering their bitterness on youth
Can't we find the minds that made us strong?
Can't we learn to feel what's right and what's wrong?
What's wrong?

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK]

[CHORUS]

Cities full of hatred, fear and lies
Withered hearts and cruel, tormented eyes
Scheming demons dressed in kingly guise
Beating down the multitude and scoffing at the wise

[OUTRO]

Oh, can't we raise our eyes and make a start?
Can't we find the minds to lead us closer to the Heart?

Finding My Way

ENCORE

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

A confident early Rush rocker about independence, desire, and moving through life on one's own terms. Its directness contrasts with the philosophical complexity of later Peart-era material. The opening track of Rush's 1974 debut album, it predates Neil Peart joining the band; Geddy Lee and Alex Lifeson wrote the music and lyrics. It provides a useful snapshot of the band before its progressive identity fully emerged.

LYRICS

[CHORUS]

Yeah, oh yeah!
Ooh, said I, I'm comin' out to get you
Ooh, sit down, I'm comin' out to find you
Ooh, yeah
Ooh, yeah
Findin' my way!

[VERSE 1]

I've been gone so long
I've lost count of the years
Well, I sang some sad songs
Oh yes, and cried some bad tears

[PRE-CHORUS]

Look out, I'm comin', woah, woah
Look out, I'm comin', woah, yeah
I'm runnin', finding my way back home
Oh, yeah!

[CHORUS]

Yeah, oh, yeah!
Ooh, said I, I'm comin' back to look for
Ooh, sit down, I'm goin' by to beg for
Ooh, yeah
Ooh, yeah
Findin' my way!

[VERSE 2]

You've done me no right
But you've done me some wrong
Left me lonely each night
While I sing my sad song

[PRE-CHORUS]

Look out, I'm comin', woah, woah
Look out, I'm comin', woah, yeah
I'm runnin', findin' my way back home

[BRIDGE]

I'm comin'
Ooh, babe, I said I'm runnin'
Woah, babe, I said I'm comin' to get you, mama
Said I'm runnin'
Ooh, babe, I said I'm comin' for you, babe, I said I'm runnin'
Ooh, yes, babe, I said I'm comin' to get you, babe
I said I'm comin'
Ooh, yeah

[PRE-CHORUS]

I'm findin', I'm findin' my way back home
Well, I've had it for now, livin' on the road
Ooh, yeah
Ooh, yeah

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK]

[GUITAR SOLO]

[PRE-CHORUS]

And I'm findin'
Findin' my way back home!
Well, I've had it for now, livin' on the road
Ooh, yeah
Ooh, yeah

[CHORUS]

Yeah
Ooh, yeah
Ooh, say now, I'm comin' out to get you
Ooh, say now, I'm comin' out to find you
Ooh, yeah
Ooh, yeah
Finding my way

By-Tor and the Snow Dog

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Fly by Night (1975), it was among the first Rush songs to demonstrate the band's interest in extended compositions. The characters originated from a humorous story involving Rush's crew and management. A theatrical fantasy battle between two larger-than-life characters. The song divides into narrative and instrumental sections, turning a simple good-versus-evil story into a progressive-rock adventure.

LYRICS

[I. AT THE TOBES OF HADES: 0:00–0:36]

[VERSE 1]

The Tobes of Hades, lit by flickering torchlight
The netherworld is gathered in the glare
Prince By-Tor takes the cavern to the north light
The sign of Eth is rising in the air

[CHORUS]

By-Tor, Knight of Darkness
Centurion of evil, Devil's Prince

[II. ACROSS THE STYX: 0:36–1:47]

[VERSE 2]

Across the River Styx, out of the lamplight
His nemesis is waiting at the gate
The Snow Dog, ermine glowing in the damp night
Coal-black eyes shimmering with hate

[CHORUS]

By-Tor and the Snow Dog
Square for battle, let the fray begin!

[OUTRO]

Ooh, yeah!

[III. THE BATTLE: 1:47–7:33]

[I. CHALLENGE AND DEFIANCE: 1:47–3:50]

[INSTRUMENTAL]

[II. 7/4 WAR FUROR: 3:50–4:42]

[INSTRUMENTAL]

[III. AFTERMATH: 4:42–6:28]

[INTERLUDE]

[IV. HYMN OF TRIUMPH: 6:28–7:33]

[GUITAR SOLO]

[IV. EPILOGUE: 7:33–8:40]

[VERSE 3]

The battle's over and the dust is clearing
Disciples of the Snow Dog sound the knell
Rejoicing echoes as the dawn is nearing
By-Tor, in defeat, retreats to Hell

[CHORUS]

Snow Dog is victorious
The land of the Overworld is saved again
Is saved again

Working Man

MEANING & HISTORICAL NOTE

Released on Rush's debut album in 1974, "Working Man" became unexpectedly popular with American rock radio, particularly in Cleveland, where WMMS helped expose the band to a wider audience. Its success played a major role in Rush's eventual breakthrough in the United States. An early celebration of the working-class identity and pride of someone whose life revolves around labor. The lyric is simple, direct, and rooted in the culture of early-1970s hard rock.

LYRICS

[VERSE 1]

Well, I get up at seven, yeah
And I go to work at nine
I got no time for livin'
Yes, I'm workin' all the time

[PRE-CHORUS]

It seems to me I could live my life
A lot better than I think I am
I guess that's why they call me
They call me the workin' man

[CHORUS]

They call me the workin' man
I guess that's what I am

[VERSE 2]

So I get home at five o'clock
And I take myself out an ice-cold beer
Always seem to be wond'rin'
Why there's nothin' goin' down here

[PRE-CHORUS]

It seems to me I could live my life
A lot better than I think I am
I guess that's why they call me
The workin' man

[CHORUS]

Well, they call me the workin' man
I guess that's what I am

[GUITAR SOLO]

[CHORUS]

Well, they call me the workin' man
I guess that's what I am

[INSTRUMENTAL BREAK]

[GUITAR SOLO]

[VERSE 1]

Well, I get up at seven, yeah
And I go to work at nine
I got no time for livin'
Yes, I'm workin' all the time

[PRE-CHORUS]

It seems to me I could live my life
A lot better than I think I am
I guess that's why they call me
They call me the workin' man

[CHORUS]

Well, they call me the workin' man
I guess that's what I am
They call me the workin' man
I guess that's what I am

[BAND OUTRO]